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Sony WF-C500

Well-defined sound and excellent fit

Sony's WF lineup of truly wireless earphones is renowned for its healthy mix of performance and features. But the company hadn't dipped its toes in the budget segment under 6K, until now. The Sony WF-C500 is the company's first attempt at a budget TWS. Let's find out how these earphones fare well in our tests and real-world scenarios.

BUILD AND COMFORT

The Sony WF-C500 features a lightweight build. The buds are primarily made out of plastic. They're rated IPX4 for sweat and splash resistance as well, making them handy for everyday listening as well as workouts.

The rounded sides of the earbuds rest comfortably against the ear while also feeling secure enough to go walking or jogging with them. The snug fit also ensures excellent passive isolation, so you don't miss ANC too much.

One gripe we do have with the earbuds is the quality of the physical controls. The buttons are also hard to press and refused to register certain actions, at times.

As for the charging case, the Sony WF-C500 has a relatively small pill-shaped case with a translucent top. While the translucent top design can look slightly cheap, it does allow you to peek inside and ascertain the battery levels without having to open up the case. The case is pretty difficult to open one-handed though.

FEATURES

The earphones are compatible with Sony's Headphone Connect app. The app lets users play with some customisation options. However, the best feature of the app is definitely the customisable equaliser. It comes with a variety of presets as well as custom sliders for the user to play around with. Customisable controls are absent on these earbuds



though, which is disappointing. As for other features, the earbuds support mono earbud use, allowing you to use either earbud independently of the other. You can also activate voice assistant by pressing and holding the right earbud. The earbuds support Google's Fast Pair and also have a feature called Swift Pair to quickly pair with Windows 10 PCs.

PERFORMANCE

The Sony WF-C500 is Sony's most inexpensive TWS yet, priced at ₹5,990. The earphones come packing 5.8mm drivers. As for audio codecs, the earphones support SBC and AAC. The earphones also feature Sony's DSEE (Digital Sound Enhancement Engine) technology which basically upscales compressed audio files by restoring high-range sound that is compromised by the compression process.

This technology coupled with Sony's prowess in sound tuning results in a pretty balanced sound profile. The earphones may just as well be one of the most detailed-sounding pairs of TWS under 6K. The only other TWS that come close at this price point are the Nothing Ear 1 and the Lypertek Pure-Play Z3. The bass response is slightly boosted but it doesn't sound muddy or bloated in the slightest. The mids are surprisingly close to neutral resulting in detailed representation of vocals and lead instruments. The highs see a significant boost, meaning elements such as cymbals and hi-hats are more present

in the mix. As for volume levels, these earphones are capable of getting pretty loud and we suggest that you listen to them around the 50-60 per cent mark. Nevertheless, even if you do raise the volume levels, the sound has minimal distortion, which is impressive.

BATTERY LIFE

The earbuds themselves are rated at 10 hours of wireless playtime which is definitely on the higher end of the spectrum even when compared to premium TWS. However, the charging holds merely one more charge, bringing the total to 20 hours which is nothing extraordinary. In our tests, with the volume set to about 60 per cent, we recorded a wireless playtime of 9.5 hours on the earbuds which does nearly stand up to Sony's claim.

VERDICT

So, what's the answer to the all-important question – should you buy the Sony WF-C500? The answer is a resounding – depends. There are two areas where these earphones clearly shine – sound quality and fit. The earphones have a balanced sonic signature with well-defined and detailed sound. Additionally, the earbuds are comfortable, have a secure fit, and are IPX4 rated making them a handy choice for workouts. However, the earphones do fall short in comparison to competitors in some areas such as total battery life, customisable controls, and transparency mode. So, if features and battery life are your primary concern, you may be better off looking at other options.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

WEIGHT: Approx. 5.4 g x2 | HEADPHONE TYPE: Closed, dynamic | DRIVER SIZE: 5.8mm | FREQUENCY RESPONSE: 20Hz - 20kHz | BATTERY LIFE (EARBUDS): 10 hours | BATTERY LIFE (WITH CASE): 10 + 10 hours | CHARGING METHOD: USB Type-C | BLUETOOTH VERSION: 5.0 | EFFECTIVE RANGE: 10m | SUPPORTED AUDIO CODECS: SBC, AAC

CONTACT

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